FOR PARENTS · SUPPORTING YOUR YOUNG PLAYER

YOUR CHILD'S FIRST TRIAL

How to prepare, what to expect and what coaches really look for

THE QUICK VERSION

> Trials can feel like a huge deal for the whole family. A little preparation goes a long way, and so does perspective. Coaches aren't looking for perfect players. They're looking for potential, attitude and players who keep trying when things don't go their way.

WHAT'S REALLY GOING ON

Most trials involve small-sided games, drills and some time to observe. Coaches usually have dozens of players to watch in a short time, so they notice the things that stand out quickly: effort, body language, communication and how a player responds after a mistake. Skill matters, but character often decides the close calls.

WHAT COACHES OFTEN LOOK FOR

01 **Effort and work rate**

02 **Positive body language**

03 **Talking to teammates**

04 **Bouncing back from mistakes**

05 **Listening and coachability**

06 **Willingness to try new things**

THE TRIAL WEEK PLAN

1

BEFORE

Check the time, place and what to bring. Pack boots, shin pads, water and a snack. Keep the week normal.

2

ON THE DAY

Arrive early, a quick hello to the coach, then step back. Let your child warm up with the group.

3

AFTER

Same as always: "I loved watching you." Whatever the result, the effort was real.

Success occurs when opportunity meets preparation.

TRY THIS

1. **Keep expectations realistic**
   Remind them a trial is one day, one squad and one coach's view.

2. **Encourage them to introduce themselves**
   A simple "Hi, I'm Ella" shows confidence and maturity.

3. **Focus on controllables**
   Effort, attitude, talking and listening. These are all in their hands.

4. **Don't coach from the sideline**
   Trials are about how they think for themselves.

5. **Plan something fun afterwards**
   A milkshake or a favourite meal makes the day about more than the result.

SAY THIS, NOT THAT

SAY THIS	NOT THAT
"Just show them how hard you work."	~~"You have to make this team."~~
"Coaches love players who talk."	~~"Don't make any mistakes."~~
"I'm proud of you for having a go."	~~"Everyone's watching, so don't mess it up."~~

QUICK SELF-CHECK

- [ ] My child knows what to bring and expect
- [ ] We've talked about what they can control
- [ ] I'll stay off the sideline coaching on the day
- [ ] I'm ready to support them whatever the result

Can't tick them all yet? That's normal. Pick one to work on this week.

COACH'S CORNER

> Players with less skill often get selected because they never stop working and never stop talking. Attitude is the easiest thing to show, and the hardest thing to coach.

THE FUTURE BALLER TEAM